



Ghanaian Methodist Fellowship – UK (GMF - UK)

Bye Laws of The Ghanaian Methodist Fellowship – UK Choir

PROFILE

Ghanaian Methodist Fellowship-UK Choir was reformed in its current structure in 2013 and is a metamorphosis of the original Choir. The Choir draws its membership from various local Methodist churches within the London District. The Choir leads the Fellowship's two services held at Methodist Central Hall, Westminster and St. Mark's Methodist Church, Tottenham in North London on second and fourth Sundays of each month at 2.30pm and 4.00pm respectively. In addition to leading the two services, the GMF-UK Choir performs at various events aimed at raising funds in support of good and charitable causes and also supports other Christian choirs in the UK.

The main aim and objective of the Choir is to bring Ghanaian choristers based in UK together and also to bring the Ghanaian form of worship and praises to our local Methodist churches in UK to enhance services.

The GMF-UK Choir specialises in Methodist hymns, local choruses and praise songs. It's first CD was produced and launched in September 2017 featuring historical and popular hymns and songs such as "Your Grace And Mercy", "I've Learnt to Trust in Jesus", "We Are Matching In The Light of God" and "Other Ghanaian Choruses".

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The name of the Choir shall be Ghanaian Methodist Fellowship - UK Choir (hereinafter referred to as “The Choir”). It shall have four harmonious singing parts namely, Soprano, Alto, Tenor and Bass.

MOTTO: Our motto and Greeting shall be “Service! with response, To God”

AIMS AND OBJECTIVES:

- ♦ To win souls for Christ through the singing of Hymns, Anthems, Choral music and praises as well as songs in Vernacular.
- ♦ To take active role in leading the GMF-UK Chaplaincy monthly Worship.
- ♦ To bring Ghanaian Choristers based in the UK together.
- ♦ To participate in special programmes such as weddings and funerals.
- ♦ To assist in Charitable and Fund-Raising events.
- ♦ To bring the Ghanaian form of praises and worship to our local Methodist churches in the UK.

1. MEMBERSHIP

Membership shall be voluntary and open to male and female members of Ghanaian Methodist Fellowship-UK and shall be from age eighteen (18) years and above.

2. ADMISSION

- i. Admission shall be by completion of an application form.
- ii. The prospective applicant will be expected to appear before the Choir Executive Committee to prove his or her eligibility and commitment.

3. PROBATIONARY PERIOD

- i) An applicant shall, on admission, serve a period of three months' probation or less depending on his/her performance.
- ii) At the end of the probationary period, the new member will be tested in chanting, rendition of hymns and songs by the Music Director/Choirmaster or Organist, after which he/she will be permitted to robe if successful. If not successful, probation will be extended, and support provided.
- iii) If an applicant still under probation proves beyond any reasonable doubt that his/her performance is good, the Music Director/Choirmaster will use his discretion to test him/her and upon successful audition, allow him/her to robe before the end of his/her probation.

4. MANAGEMENT

The general management of the Choir shall be vested in the Choir Executive Committee as stated in the GMF-UK Guidebook.

5. APPOINTMENT OF OFFICERS AND TENURE OF OFFICE

- i) Apart from the Music Director/Choirmaster, the Organist and their assistants who are appointed by the Chaplaincy Management Committee (CMC) with the Executive of the Choir, all other officers shall be elected at a general meeting by a simple majority.
- ii) Part Leaders and their Assistants shall be nominated by the Part members in consultation with the Executive Committee.
- iii) The tenure of office for all elected officers shall be a term of two (2) years each. An Officer shall not be eligible for re-election to the same office after a second term unless he/she wins seventy-five percent (75%) of the vote.
- iv) Nominations committee: This is an Ad hoc committee of three (3) members. It will be solely for election purposes.

- v) By Election: This will take place when an Executive member resigns or is removed from post.

6. DUTIES OF THE OFFICERS

I CHOIRMASTER (ADMINISTRATOR)

- a. Choirmaster shall be the principal leader/ administrator of the choir's affairs.
- b. In the absence of the Choirmaster, the Immediate Choirmaster or the Precentor can act on his/her behalf.

II MUSIC DIRECTOR /ORGANIST

- a. He/she must have a good knowledge of music, and his musicianship should not be confined to teaching and directing the Choir alone.
- b. He/she should have a good singing voice and the ability to sing properly. A rich and resonant leading voice coming from the Music Director/Organist adds stature to his own personality as a singing instructor and inspires the Choir. His ability to sing well will help to correct individual faults in singing and thereby raise the image of the Choir.
- c. The Music Director/Organist in conjunction with the Choirmaster should be able to plan the work of the Choir in such a way that it can give a special performance from time to time. He/she should have a large repertoire from which to choose and should be willing to conduct research into various types of sacred music, both indigenous and foreign. He/she should also be competent in the art of conducting.
- d. The Organist shall be responsible for the entire choral accompaniment and efficient performance of the Choir.
- e. The Organist shall assist the Music Director in the teaching of music and administer the Choir in his absence.

III VISITING ORGANIST/MUSICIAN

The Visiting Organist/Musician shall work in conjunction with or under the instruction of the Music Director and Choirmaster.

IV. PRECENTOR

- a) The Precentor shall be Spiritual Head and responsible for the overall maintenance of discipline of the choir.
- b) He/she shall lead the Choir in prayers before and after services.
- c) He/she shall have control over the Curators and see to the proper performance of their duties.
- d) He/she shall bring to the notice of the Music Director/Choirmaster persistent cases of indiscipline.
- e) In view of the importance of his/her office, the Precentor shall be a member of the Choir for a minimum of three (3) years prior to his/her election.
- f) He/she shall, when consulted, give sympathetic hearing to the pastoral needs of members.

V. SECRETARY

- a) The Secretary shall record the minutes of all meetings and handle all correspondence of the Choir.
- b) He/she shall also act as a Liaison Officer between the Choir and its outside publics.
- c) He/she shall in consultation with the Music Director/Choirmaster convene all meetings.

VI. ASSISTANT SECRETARY

- a) The Assistant Secretary shall assist the Secretary in the discharge of his/her duties and keep the Master Roll Book.
- b) To liaise between Patrons and the Choir.

VII. FINANCIAL SECRETARY

- a) The Financial Secretary shall record all monies received/paid out.
- b) He/she shall issue receipt for monies received by the Choir.
- c) He/she shall prepare any statement of bills to the Treasurer for payment.
- d) He/she shall present the income and expenditure accounts quarterly to the Choir Executive Committee.

VIII. TREASURER

- a) The Treasurer shall keep an accurate account of the Choir's funds.
- b) Every amount paid out shall be authorized by the Choir Executive Committee.
- c) He/she shall keep an imprest to be determined by the Choir Executive Committee.

IX. LEAD CURATOR

- a) The Lead Curator shall be responsible to the Precentor.
- b) He/she shall be in direct charge of the Vestry and all the properties of the Choir.
- c) The Lead Curator shall ensure that the robes, hymn books, leaflets, etc. are systematically arranged in their respective places in the Vestry.
- d) He/she shall be the last person to leave the meeting place to ensure that all the windows and doors are properly locked and that any item left behind is kept safely.

X. OTHER CURATOR(S):

All other Curators shall assist the Lead Curator in discharge of his/her duties.

XI. PART LEADERS:

- a) There shall be a principal leader and an assistant for each of the four (4) parts, and it shall be the responsibility of the Part Leaders to maintain order and discipline in their various sections, both at practices and at Church services.
- b) It shall be the responsibility of the Part leader to check up on his/her members from time to time.
- c) They will inform the Welfare Officer of a Part member's sickness with permission from the member.
- d) They will inform the Welfare Officer of a Part member's sickness with permission from the member.

XII. LEAD WELFARE OFFICER

- a) He/she shall ensure that the sick and bereaved members are promptly visited and comforted.
- b) He/she shall ensure to the Choir's proper participation, on invitation, to social functions such as marriages, out-doorings, funerals, and other activities.
- c) He/she shall arrange for transportation and refreshment for the Choir's outings and programmes.
- d) He/she will assist in the liaison of Patrons and the Choir.

XIII. WELFARE OFFICERS

The welfare Officers will work as a Team under the Lead Welfare Officer.

XIV. PATRONS

- a) There shall be Patrons of the Choir.

- b) Patrons shall be members of the Ghanaian Methodist Fellowship or any of the Christian Communities in the UK and other parts of the world, who show interest in the activities of the Choir.
- c) Nominations of Patrons shall be made by members of the choir or individuals who approach the choir and show interest.
- d) New Patrons will be invited to appear before Executive Committee for interaction before approval. (e) They can also be “Ex Officio” members of the choir, in advisory capacity.
- e) They shall assist the Choir spiritually, financially, materially, and socially.
- f) They shall meet periodically to give constructive feedback of the Choir’s performance in general and offer corrective suggestions.
- g) They shall co-ordinate with the Choir Executive Committee on issues affecting the running of the Choir.
- h) They shall co-ordinate with the Choir Executive Committee on issues affecting the running of the Choir.
- i) They shall be encouraged to participate in programmes of the Choir.
- j) The Choir shall support the Patrons when the need arises.
- k) Patron’s performance is subject to review after every two (2) years according to the individual’s performance.
- l) The choir will meet its Patrons twice in a year.
- m) They can also be contacted for other meetings when the need arises.

7. DUTIES OF THE EXECUTIVE COMMITTEE

- i. There shall be a Choir Executive Committee, which shall be constituted by all the officers of the Choir with the Choirmaster as its Chairperson.
- ii. The Choir Executive Committee shall meet once every month. Nevertheless, the Choirmaster may call other meetings, whenever necessary.
- iii. The Executive Committee shall have the discretionary powers to take decisions on behalf of the Choir in exceptional circumstances.

8. GENERAL MEETING & AGM OF THE CHOIR

There shall be two general meetings and one Annual General Meeting (AGM) in the year, at which accounts, elections (every two years) and general performance of the Choir during the year shall be discussed. Voting at all general meetings shall be by simple majority. However, additional general meetings can be called where necessary.

9. CHOIR PRACTICE

- i. There shall be two (2) Choir practices in the month and such days shall be first/second (1st/2nd) and fourth (4th) Saturdays of the month.
- ii. The duration of Choir practices shall not exceed two and half (2.5) hours 6.00p.m - 8.30p.m depending on the session.
- iii. In exceptional circumstances and at the discretion of the Music Director/Choirmaster, additional practice days and time shall be added.
- iv. The first Choir practice day shall be used to prepare for Sunday services.

10. ATTENDANCE AT PRACTICE

- i. Any chorister who intends to be absent from Choir practice or Sunday service must inform his/her Part Leader and appropriate action taken.
- ii. Any chorister who fails to attend Choir practices regularly or Sunday services for three (3) months shall be required to explain his/her conduct to the Part Leader and Choirmaster.
- iii. Any chorister who stays away from Choir practices and Church Services for six (6) consecutive months or more without seeking permission shall be presumed to have deserted the Choir and shall forfeit any benefit due to him/her.
- iv. Any chorister who stays away from Choir practices and Church Services for one (1) year shall be accepted into the Choir as a new member and would have to go through the process of serving a probationary period of three (3) months.
- v. Choristers who go to further their education or training shall formally seek permission to be away and are expected to return to the Choir during vacations.
- vi. Any chorister who absents himself/herself from first Choir practice shall not be eligible to robe on the Sunday. (The Saturday before Central Hall Service. This is subject to Choirmaster and Music Director's discretion).
- vii. Any chorister who absents himself/herself from Choir practice without permission for more three months shall not be eligible to robe the very month he/she attends Choir practice. This shall be subject to Choirmaster/Music Director's discretion.
- viii. Any Chorister who absents him/herself for one year without permission shall be made a dormant member and his /her membership will be reviewed only when he /she resumes full choir practices for at least three months.
- ix. Every chorister must avail himself/herself of the means of GRACE of the British Methodist Church and the GMF-UK

- at large i.e. Fellowship services, Sacrament, fund-raising etc.
- x. Every Chorister shall be at the Vestry, at least, fifteen (15) minutes before the commencement of service, except where permission has been granted not to process or recess.
 - xi. No Chorister shall robe to join the Choir at the stalls after the singing of the introit. (This is subject to Choirmaster/Music Director discretion in exceptional circumstances).
 - xii. Any member who has submitted a permission letter due to work, education or long distance must attend at least three consecutive practices before he/she is allowed to robe or join the choir at Church services and other programmes.

11. DRESS CODE

i. Music Director /Choirmasters/Organists

He/she shall dress like any other male chorister; in simple **WHITE LONG SLEEVES SHIRT**, He may choose to wear a **SUIT AND A GOWN TO CONFORM TO THE REQUIREMENTS OF THE QUALIFICATION AWARDED COLLEGE. A BLACK BOW OR FLYING TIE MAY BE WORN OVER A PAIR OF BLACK SHOES**. No Organist shall put on the gown whilst in political suit or shirt without a coat or jacket and **NO ORGANIST SHALL PLAY THE ORGAN AT A CHURCH FUNCTION OR CONDUCT THE CHOIR WITHOUT THE GOWN**.

ii. Male Choristers

Male choristers are to wear **WHITE LONG SLEEVES SHIRT over DARK COLOURED TROUSERS** not in contrast with the robes. **BLACK FLYING or BOW TIE, BLACK SHOES AND SOCKS** to match the colour of the Trousers is recommended. There should be no colouring of hair, tattooing or skinheads.

iii. **Lady Choristers**

Personal dress, except for trousers, should not show beneath the robes. It should be turned up or drawn up and pinned. Sleeves should be rolled up.

a) **Hairdo/Hairstyle**

The hairdo/hairstyle must be portable and free style. Long hairs must be held up with grips/pins except where the hair is natural grey hair, no female chorister shall be allowed to robe with a multi-coloured or bleached hair. There should be no colouring of hair, tattooing or skinheads.

b) **Earrings and Neck/Ankle Chains or Bangles**

Earrings shall be uniform (The choir's own prescribed) or otherwise it shall be flat, round/ ball in gold-plated or white in colour and shall be fixed to the ear but **NOT HANGING/ DANGLING. NO NECK OR ANKLE CHAINS** shall be worn. **NO BANGLES** of any kind whatsoever shall also be worn. **FANCIFUL RINGS ARE NOT ACCEPTABLE**

c) **Make-Up**

- i. NO make-up, such as EYE SHADOWS, RED OR MULTI-COLOURED LIPSTICKS and ROSY CHEEKS shall be applied whilst in robes. However neutral colours will be considered.
- ii. NO long false nails shall be worn.

d) **Shoes**

A pair of full **BLACK SHOES** is prescribed. **OPEN-TOE SANDALS or SLIPPERS** are not acceptable.

e) **Bags**

No bags shall hang over the robes at the shoulder. A portable handbag or purse could be secured at the armpit through the sleeves, if necessary, to hold a few essentials.

WEARING OF CHOIR ROBES AND CLOTH

Black Robes

1. Ordinary Sunday services
2. Covenant service
3. Memorial at conferences
4. Burial service
5. Re-dedication service
6. Induction Service
7. Singing competition at conferences

Ceremonial Robe (Purple Robes)

1. Christmas Day (when it falls on Sunday)
2. Easter Sunday
3. Induction service for Rev. Ministers
4. Synod Official Opening

Yellow Cloth

1. Palm Sunday
2. Christmas (When it does not fall on Sunday)
3. Choir Anniversary
4. Chorister's wedding
5. Conference Sunday

GHAMECC @ 40 Cloth (Purple and Blue)

1. Performances at conference
2. Chorister's wedding (on request)
3. Musical Concerts

On National Conference Sunday, all delegates at the venue should wear robes. The choir cloth would be worn by all Choristers in the Connexion to signify that, conference is ongoing in the Connexion. The Choir must give the church Leadership prior notice before wearing the choir cloth.

On occasions like weddings, members can request for specific uniforms or robes.

Tee – Shirts

1. A member's one-week funeral gathering.
2. Choir Retreat
3. GMF-UK Games

Any other event as determined by Executives.

Black and White

To be determined by Executive.

PLEASE NOTE: Choristers who do not robe but wear other organisation's uniforms for various reasons cannot join the Choir during performance. If it is their anniversary, they can robe for the first part of the service and disrobe to join their organisation for the second part of the service.

12. FUNDS

- i) A Savings Bank/Current Account shall be opened with the GMF-UK bank account.
- ii) An imprest of not more than £100 shall be kept by the Treasury. This is subject to review.
- iii) Withdrawals from the Bank shall only be made on the authority of the Choir Executive Committee.
- iv) The request for the purpose of all transactions shall be made by the Choir Treasurer/Financial Secretary to the Chaplaincy Treasurer and copies to Choirmaster, Secretariat, Welfare and Precentor.

13. ACCOUNTS

- i. The financial year of the Choir shall commence on the first of September and end on 31st August.
- ii. A financial report shall be submitted every six months by the Financial Secretary to the Choir Executive Committee for its consideration. A yearly Financial Report shall be submitted for adoption at the Annual General Meeting (AGM) of the Choir.

14. EXAMINATION OF ACCOUNTS

The Accounts of the Choir shall be independently examined yearly by an Independent Examiner to be appointed by the Choir Executive Committee.

15. INVENTORY

An inventory of all properties in the care of the Curator shall be recorded in an Inventory Book and kept in the Vestry and shall be checked yearly by the Lead Curator, who shall submit an Inventory Report to the Choir Executive Committee.

16. CHOIR PROPERTIES

- i. No property of the Choir (robe, hymn book, etc.) shall be taken home or to any function unless with the approval of the Choirmaster in consultation with the Curator and the Precen-tor.
- ii. No chorister shall wear or tamper with any robe which is assigned to a fellow chorister unless authorized by the Precen-tor or Lead Curator.
- iii. Hymn books, leaflets, etc. shall not be carelessly handled or placed about in the Vestry; the Curator shall pile them together for shelving. Similarly, all robes shall be hung on the pegs provided for the purpose.

NO PERSONAL CHOIR ROBE is PERMITTED to be worn at any time.

17. PRESENTATIONS

The Choir, on anniversaries, shall make presentations to outstanding choristers.

18. WEDDINGS

- i. A disturbance fee shall be charged by the Choir for weddings and other functions not within the general requirements of the Church for which application for such service of the Choir shall be made.
- ii. Where one of the couples is a member of the Choir, no fee shall be charged for attendance at a wedding service.
- iii. A suitable presentation shall be made to any member of the Choir at the time of wedlock, in accordance with our welfare provision.

19. SICKNESS

- i. A chorister who falls sick, shall arrange to inform the Part Leader and on his /her approval, the Part Leader shall then inform the Welfare Officer as appropriate.
- ii. If a chorister is admitted at the hospital or is seriously sick at home, the Choir shall visit the said chorister and present some provisions or fruits: From £10 to £20 is recommended subject to review.
- iii. Members with long term sickness should be visited twice a year. £25 - £30.

20. BEREAVEMENTS

- a) Permission shall be sought from CMC for the Choir to attend all funerals.
- b) If a parent of a chorister dies, the Choir shall attend the funeral of the deceased.
- c) If a spouse of a chorister dies, the Choir shall attend the funeral of the deceased.
- d) Where a child of a chorister dies, all the members of the Choir shall go and sympathize with the bereaved chorister up till the time of burial.
- e) If a parent/spouse/child dies, the Choir shall robe upon request which will be considered by the Executive for the burial service.
- f) When a chorister dies, the Choir shall visit the bereaved family and console them through prayers, hymns, and scripture.
- g) The Choir shall put red puppy bands on their robes every subsequent Sunday till the deceased chorister is buried.
- h) No matter the distance, the Choir is encouraged to attend the burial and funeral of the deceased chorister in full.
- i) Where the Choir is unable to attend the burial and funeral in full due to distance and financial constraints, a sizeable delegation or a letter from the CMC requesting the participation of a home Choir to represent the Choir with a donation.
- j) The Choir shall present a tribute.
- k) A service of songs shall be held on one of the Choir practice days in the week preceding the burial of the deceased chorister. The entire membership of the Choir dressed in the Association's T-Shirt shall attend. The service shall not exceed two hours and shall be conducted by a Reverend Minister.
- l) The Choir shall inform the family and the local Minister of the part the Choir would play in the funeral.

- m) A donation shall be presented to the appropriate person or persons as custom demands, but the donation to be presented shall depend on whether the chorister is of good financial standing or not.

21. DISOBEDIENCE

It shall be a serious offence for a chorister to refuse to abide by any order issued out by the Music Director/Choirmaster or an accredited representative/Executive Member, either directly or indirectly and such offender shall be summoned to appear before the Choir Executive Committee to show cause why he/she should not be suspended or dismissed.

FOR THE AVOIDANCE OF DOUBT, THE CHOIR EXECUTIVE COMMITTEE SHALL HAVE AUTHORITY TO SUSPEND A CHORISTER WHO MISBEHAVES FOR UP TO THREE MONTHS, BUT WHERE STIFFER PUNISHMENT IS REQUIRED, THE EXECUTIVE COMMITTEE AND CMC SHALL HAVE THE FINAL SAY.

22. DISCIPLINE

- i. It shall be an offence to talk or converse at Choir practices and Church services.
- ii. NO humming of tune shall take place whilst the organ is being played.
- iii. NO chorister shall quarrel or use indecent language either within or outside the Choir.
- iv. There shall be PERFECT SILENCE in the stalls and every chorister is duty bound to be in the mood for prayers and perfect reverence.
- v. There shall be NO chewing of gum, at Choir practice, Church service, Performances or at the Vestry before service commences.

- vi. There should be no loitering during church services, choir practice and programmes. However, permission can be sought from the Choirmaster before the service and where possible, the member can disrobe for easy access.
- vii. All insubordination shall be dealt with as a breach of discipline and shall attract long suspension or dismissal, depending on the degree of the offence.

23. PROCEDURE AS TO DISCIPLINE

- i. In all matters of discipline, the final authority shall be the CMC.
- ii. Where a chorister misbehaves in a way that deserves suspension and/or dismissal, the Choir Executive Committee shall, in the first instance, suspend the chorister concerned for up to three months and a formal report made to the CMC, whilst investigations are conducted into the matter within two (2) months.
- iii. At the end of the investigations, an emergency meeting of the Choir Executive Committee shall be convened to look at the report and a recommendation based on the report submitted to CMC for a final decision to be taken on the matter.
- iv. However, where it becomes expedient to recall the suspended chorister before the expiration of the suspension period, the Choir Executive Committee shall recall the chorister concerned, without prejudice to the report of the investigations to be submitted later.
- v. Members have the right to appeal against disciplinary action.
- vi. A member shall be reinstated if he/she is vindicated of all charges.

24. DISMISSALS/RESIGNATIONS

- a) Any chorister who fails to comply with the rules and regulations of the Choir shall lose his/her membership on the recommendation of the Choir Executive Committee.
- b) If a member is dismissed, he/she loses every benefit and there will be no compensation.
- c) If a member is repentant and wants to re-join the choir,
- d) The Executive Committee should make the final decision as to whether to accept his/her application or not.

25. INTOXICATION AND/OR DRUNKENNESS/ SUBSTANCE ABUSE

- i. It shall be a serious offence on the part of any chorister to attend Choir practice and Church service under the influence of alcohol or other substance of abuse.
- ii. Such a chorister shall be turned away by the Part Leader from Choir practice or be made to disrobe and a report made to the Precentor who shall warn the chorister to desist from drinking or substance abuse.
- iii. A report of such behaviour shall be reported to the Choir Executive Committee for the chorister to be suspended.
- iv. A further incidence of substance abuse (e.g. drunkenness) shall require the Choir Executive Committee to provide support where necessary to the chorister.
- v. A proper record can be kept as evidence for this issue based on the acceptance of the affected member.
- vi. Failure to accept the support will result in the matter being referred to the CMC.

26. IMMORAL ACTS

Any chorister (married) found to be having extra marital affair with any female/male chorister shall be investigated and subsequently suspended on the recommendation of the Choir Executive Committee.

However, any chorister who is eager to choose a life partner within the Choir is advised to do so through the proper channel (e.g. Choirmaster, CMC).

The decision to either dismiss or suspend the said chorister indefinitely shall be taken by the Choir Executive Committee on the receipt of the report of investigation, and CMC informed for the necessary action to be taken.

An Executive member who is suspended shall lose his position on the Choir Executive Committee.

27. SPIRITUAL DEVELOPMENT OF CHORISTERS

- i. The Choir shall institute a 'Choir Re-Dedication Service on the 2nd Sunday of October every year in full choir robes. The Service shall be conducted by a Reverend Minister appointed for the purpose.
- ii. The Choir shall, from time to time, also organize Spiritual Retreats to enhance the spiritual growth of choristers and cater for their special spiritual needs.

28. MONTHLY DUES

The Choir dues will be raised from £20 yearly to £60 a year (£5 monthly). This is subject to review.

Members will be encouraged to pay their monthly dues regularly.

29. DISCRETIONARY POWERS

The Choir Executive Committee shall deliberate and decide on all matters, which are not stipulated in these rules as they arise from time to time, without prejudice.

These Bye Laws may be repealed or amended by a majority vote of not less than three quarters of members in good standing at a General Meeting.

30. GMF-UK CHOIR WELFARE POLICY

This welfare policy is instituted by the GMF-UK Choir to cater for the general welfare needs of all members of the Choir. By default, all members of the Choir will participate in and are entitled to the benefits of the welfare scheme. This single welfare policy applies to all Choristers.

WELFARE NEEDS

Members' welfare needs or entitlements can be identified as the choir's responsibilities towards members in times of death and/or birth, sickness and at special occasions such as weddings and birthdays.

At all times, what the Choir would endeavour to project would not necessarily be the financial support, but rather the love and moral encouragement that would flow from the entire Choir to the affected member. For example, when a member is bereaved, the entire Choir will be encouraged to adopt the practice we are used to at home by visiting and phoning the bereaved member and volunteering to help in any way required. Such show of love would always supersede any material help given.

BENEFITS

a) Bereavements

All death entitlements will be limited to the following:

- i. Death of a Chorister (Donation) £1,000.00 plus £50 worth of drinks.
- ii. Spouse of a Chorister (Wife/Husband) £500.00 plus £30 worth of drinks.
- iii. Parents of a Chorister (Father/Mother or two nominated parents £500.00) plus £30 worth of drinks.

One child of a Chorister £200.00 plus £30 worth of drinks

These are subject to review.

On the death of a Chorister of the fellowship where the spouse is also a Chorister, the surviving spouse will be entitled to claim both benefits **i** and **ii**.

Parent, in this sense, means biological parent only, or legally adopted parent. Members who have already lost their parents can nominate a parent in lieu.

Members who have benefited either in the old or this current Choir for one or both parents before the adoption of this By-laws cannot benefit anymore.

b) Christening, Weddings/Marriages, Birthdays

When Chorister is celebrating any of these events, and where the Choir is officially invited, a token donation, together with an appropriate card signed by members of the fellowship will be given to the host as follows:

- i. Christening £50 per child (2 children)
- ii. Wedding/Marriages £200 and £400 if both are Choristers (One off payment)
- iii. Birthday £100

Birthday benefits will only apply starting from age 40 and for subsequent decades, i.e. 50, 60, 70, 80 and upwards. This will be one off payment.

c) Farewell

Where a Chorister is migrating from the U.K. for good, a farewell benefit will be paid to the member accompanied by an appropriate card signed by members of the Choir. This benefit will only be paid once and will be subject to the Executive's decision/approval.

d) Sickness

When a member of the Choir is taken ill, and hospitalized or recovering at home, it is incumbent on the Welfare Team to make regular visitations as well as phone contacts when permitted. A get-well card signed by members of the Choir and a token donation not exceeding £50 may also be sent to the affected member (This is a one-off payment). The Welfare Committee will determine each case on its own merit within agreed set of criteria.

FUNDING

Levies will be collected for special occasions or events such as funerals, weddings, christening etc.

Payments of Levies

- i) Members of the Choir will be issued with individual membership cards for recording the payment of all dues and other levies instituted by the Choir. Treasurers of the Choir will collect and record these donations on behalf of the Choir.
- ii) Any remaining amount from the levies, after a donation is made will be paid into the Choir's coffers.
- iii) The Finance Team (FT) will study these records and take appropriate action to ensure that members keep up their contributions. If necessary, the FT will contact defaulters and discuss any issues necessary to bring all payments up to date.

- iv) It must be pointed out that regular and continuous payment of special contributions will be a measure of whether one qualifies for benefit or not.
- v) If you miss 3 payments of special contributions and monthly dues, then you will not qualify for any benefit.

ATTENDANCE AT EVENTS

It is required of every member of the Choir welfare scheme to endeavour to be present at all events the Choir is invited to. Attendance book will be available for members to sign in. The Welfare and Secretariat Team will be responsible to mark the register and to keep accurate records of attendance. This book will also contain a page/section indicating members who qualify for entitlement.

PAYMENT OF BENEFITS

Benefit entitlements will be paid as early as possible. In the case of bereavements, the benefit will usually be paid as soon as possible and in consultation with the bereaved Chorister. For other events and celebrations benefits may be paid on the day of the event if not earlier.

The practice whereby somebody goes round collecting members' contributions at functions will be discontinued.

When attending functions, members of the Choir will gather and contribute a song or two, share a word of encouragement and pray for the host if appropriate.

WELFARE GROUPINGS

- a) Membership will be open to **ALL** and would be organised along existing structures within the Choir namely Finance Team and Part Leaders.
- b) All bereavements and events that affect members of the choir welfare scheme must be reported to the Welfare Team.

QUALIFICATION PERIOD

There is a probation period of six months for new members from date of registration when members will not be entitled to any benefits.

Welfare and Secretariat Teams should have the responsibility of announcements at functions. The Choir Executive shall be responsible for reviewing the composition of the Welfare Team to enable it to perform its functions more effectively.

OTHER RESPONSIBILITIES

The Welfare Team will be responsible for other duties assigned to it from time to time by the Choir Executive.

ACCEPTANCE AND APPROVAL

This Bye Laws has been accepted as binding by the Ghanaian Methodist Fellowship-UK Choir at a General Meeting held on 22nd May 2021

NATIONAL CHOIR ANTHEM BY E. C BILSON SNR

SERVICE to God!
We 'll with heart and voice
Sing of His praise,
Aloud in all the earth

*Together let us sing to God,
Whose goodness faileth never.
We'll sing and praise the Lord:
For evermore.*

SERVICE to God!
We'll sing His love forever,
Sing to His Power
And Glorify His name

SERVICE to God
We'll serve the Lord with gladness;
Sing unto Him,
Exalt and bless His name

SERVICE to God!
To Him be glory given
Sing to the Lord,
Whom Heav'n and Earth adore

VESTRY PRAYERS

(All Choristers are advised to memorise the Vestry Prayer)

Precentor: Let us remember that we are in the sight and presence of God

(The choir to sing a hymn)

Prayers: Almighty and Loving Father, Supreme Ruler of the universe, we praise and magnify thy Holy Name for choosing us to win souls for Thy service through Thy wonderful gift of voice, music, and song. We surrender ourselves to Thy service and dedicate all our talents to Thee. Be gracious unto us, O lord, and help us to lead a disciplined life in thought, in word and in deed. To the honour and glory of thy Holy Name, Amen.

(Choir to put on their surplice and jabots)

Precentor: The Lord is in Holy Temple

Choir: Cleanse me O lord, and keep me pure, that I may be numbered amongst those happy ones who clothed in white, stand before Thy throne and serve Thee day and night in Thy temple in Heaven. Amen.

(Before going to the Stalls)

Precentor: Prevent us O lord, in all our doings, with Thy most gracious favour and further us with Thy continual help; that in all our works begun, continued and ended in Thee, we may glorify Thy Holy Name and finally by Thy mercy, obtain everlasting life through Jesus Christ Our Lord. Amen.

Precentor: O Lord, open thou our lips.

Choir: And our mouths shall show forth Thy praise.

Precentor: O Lord, purify our hearts.

Choir: That we may worthily magnify Thy Holy Name.
Amen.

THE LORD'S PRAYER

Precentor: *Announce the processional hymn and introit*

Prayers after service before disrobing

Choir: Grant, O Lord, that what we have heard with our ears and sung with our lips, we may believe in our hearts and what we believe in our hearts, we may show forth in our lives through Jesus Christ our Lord. Amen.

SERVICE OF RE-DEDICATION (all choristers to stand)

Minister: Do you believe in your heart that you have been endowed with graces for singing, and also do you feel led by the Spirit of God to serve Him in the Church's singing ministry?

Choristers: I do so believe, and I feel led by the Spirit of God to do so.

Minister: Will you be diligent in prayer, in the reading of the Holy Scriptures and in other means of grace necessary to equip you spiritually for your service to GOD in singing?

Choristers: I will, by GOD's grace.

Minister: Will you be loyal to the Church and accept the authority of the music directors as well as those in whom the Church has committed the direction of your service in the Church's ministry?

Choristers: I will, the LORD being my helper.

Minister: To the glory of GOD, the Father,
To the glory of GOD, the Son,
To the glory of GOD, the Holy Spirit. AMEN.

Dear choristers, you have been called to a service of re-dedication in the Church's singing ministry at the beginning of another year. I, therefore, ask you to make public testimony of your commitment.

For songs that will inspire a service of dedication and commitment to JESUS CHRIST, the Son of God.

Choristers: I re-dedicate myself.

Minister: For songs that will provide spiritual healing to the broken hearted.

Choristers: I re-dedicate myself.

Minister: For songs that will wash away from the soul the dust of everyday life.

Minister: In the power of the love of GOD, in the grace of our LORD and Saviour JESUS CHRIST, and in the fellowship of the Holy Spirit, our Comforter.

Choristers: I re-dedicate myself.

Officiating Minister shall raise his/her hand towards the choristers and say:

Minister: In humble adoration to the Triune God before whom angels and arch-angels, and all the hierarches of heaven fall prostrate, ever adoring and ceaselessly crying antiphonally around the throne, Holy, Holy, Holy, Lord God of hosts.

Choristers: We re-dedicate ourselves and our service this day to the glory of God the Father, God the Son and God the Holy Spirit, one God, world without end.
AMEN.

Minister: Let us pray (all seated)

Eternal GOD, the Father of our LORD JESUS CHRIST, look favourably upon these your servants who have re-dedicated themselves to your services this day. Grant that they may have strength of body, mind and soul for the fulfilment of your will, that they may worthily discharge the singing ministry committed to them to the blessing of humankind and the glory of CHRIST our Saviour. AMEN.

Minister: THE CHARGE

Beloved choristers, go and do as you have declared in the Name of God the Father, God the Son and God the Holy Spirit. Now to Him, who by the power at work in us is able to do far more abundantly than we ask or think, to Him be glory in the Church and through CHRIST JESUS to all generations, for ever and ever. AMEN!

ORDER OF SERVICE FOR BURIAL OF A CHORISTER

THE BURIAL OF A CHORISTER SHALL BE A CELEBRATION,

WITH HYMNS AND SONGS, AND THEREFORE THIS SHOULD BE WELL REHEARSED. IT IS THEREFORE IMPORTANT FOR ALL CHOIRS TO LEARN TO SING THE FOLLOWING

1. Canticle 2 (Tune 34A by J. H. Maunder)
2. Canticle 10 (Tune E by W. Croft)
3. Canticle 72 (Tune 64 by P. Humphrey)
4. Canticle 74 (Tune 20A by L. Flintoft)
5. "In Memoriam"
6. "Heaven"
7. "Hom Ntaa Dzinn"
8. "Hallelujah Chorus"

PRE-BURIAL SERVICE

1. All choristers shall dress ready to robe and sit at the stalls.
2. The Choir shall lead the pre-burial service to sing hymns and songs as directed the Minister-in-charge of the service.
3. Throughout the service up to when the Sermon is about to be delivered, two (2) choristers would guard the coffin bearing the body of the deceased choristers at five (5) minutes intervals.
4. During the Choir's turn to pay its final respect, all choristers shall surround the coffin bearing the body of the deceased chorister whilst singing.
5. A prayer shall be said to be followed immediately with Canticle 10.
6. The Choir's tribute shall then be read, if the Choir is requested to do so by the Minister. Where the Minister would want the Choir's tribute to be read during the main burial service, the pre-burial ceremony shall end with the singing of the "In Memoriam".
7. After the tribute, the Choir shall sing "In Memoriam" and sing a hymn before the choristers move back to the stalls.

MAIN BURIAL SERVICE

1. The Choir in full shall first sing Canticle 74 before processing.
2. WHEN THE Choir is called upon to read the tribute, all choristers shall stand and interlude/Hymn or Service to God shall be sung after which the tribute shall be read.

AFTER THE SERVICE BENEDICTION

1. “Hom Ntaa Dzinn”, the words for Dead March in Saul in Akan shall be sung.
2. “Hallelujah Chorus” shall be sing after the benediction as the ‘last post’ for the departed brother.

AT THE BURIAL GROUND

1. The anthem, “Heaven” shall be sing.
2. After the benediction, either Canticle 10 or the Te Deum Laudamus shall be sung.





GHANAIAN METHODIST FELLOWSHIP –UK CHOIR
(GMF-UK CHOIR)